

Session 23: Abraham's Ultimate Test

Key Takeaways

- Moriah means “seeing,” and it’s a strong thematic connection to the test in the garden of Eden.
- The theme of the test in the Bible has two sides: positively, it can be an opportunity to prove loyalty and preparedness; negatively, it can be a temptation or a trap.
- God commands Avraham to offer Yitskhaq as a “going-up” offering—a whole offering of total surrender.
- The New Testament links Jesus’ trial in the garden of Gethsemane to the test Avraham faces in Genesis 22.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 22:1-19

¹ And it came about after these things,
that Elohim tested Avraham,

and he said to him,
“Avraham.”

And he said,
“Look, it’s me!”

² And he said,
“Please **take your son** ,
your only one ,
whom you love ,
Yitskhaq ,
and get yourself going to the land of **Moriah [“Seeing” = (מריה)]** ,
and **make him go up there as a going-up offering** ,
on one of **the mountains which I will say to you** .”

³ And Avraham rose early in the morning,
and he bound up his **donkey** ,
and he **took**
two of his **young men** with him
and **Yitskhaq his son** ,
and he split the **wood** of **the going-up offering** ,
and he arose and he went to **the place which Elohim said to him** .

4 On the third day,
then Avraham **lifted his eyes** ,
and he saw (ראה) **the place** from a distance.

5 And Avraham said to his young men,
"Sit yourselves here with the **donkey**,
and I and the **young boy**,
we will go to there,
and **we will** worship,
and **we will** return to you."

6 And Avraham took the **wood** of **the going-up offering** ,
and he placed upon **Yitskhaq his son** ,
and he took in his hand the **fire** and the **eater [= knife]** ,
and the two of them went, together as one.

7 **And Yitskhaq said to Avraham his father** ,
and he said,
"**My father** ."

And he said,
"Look, it's me, **my son** ."

And he said,
"Look, the **fire** and the **wood** ,
but where is the **sheep** for **the going-up offering** ?"

8 **And Avraham said**,
"Elohim **will see to it (יראה)** , the **sheep** for **the going-up offering** , **my son** ."
And the two of them went, together as one.

9 And they went to **the place which Elohim said to him** ,
and Avraham built there an altar,
and he arranged the **wood** ,
and he bound up **Yitskhaq his son** ,
and he placed him upon the altar atop the **wood** ,

10 and Avraham **sent out his hand** ,
and he took the **eater [= knife]** to slay **his son** ,

11 **and the messenger of Yahweh called to him from the skies** ,
and he said,

"Avraham! Avraham!"

and he said,
"Look, it's me!"

12 **And he said**,
"**Don't send out your hand** toward the young one!
And don't do anything to him,

because now I know that you are one who fears Elohim,
and you didn't withhold **your son, your only one**, from me."

¹³ And Avraham **lifted his eyes**,
and **he saw** (ראה), and look, a **ram** afar, caught in a bramble by its horns,
and Avraham went and he took the **ram**,
and **he made it go up as a going-up offering** in the place of **his son**,
¹⁴ and Avraham called the name of **that place**,
"Yahweh **will see to it** (יראה)."
Which is why, today, it is said,
"On **the mountain of Yahweh**, **it will be seen to** (יראה)."

¹⁵ **And the messenger of Yahweh called to Avraham a second time from the skies**,

¹⁶ and he said,
" **I swear an oath** (שבוע) by myself, utterance of Yahweh,
on account of the fact that you did this thing,
and you did not withhold **your son, your only one**,
a ¹⁷ that I will certainly **bless** you,
b and I will certainly **multiply** **your seed**,
c **like the stars of the skies**,
c' and **like the sand upon the edge of the sea**,
b' and **your seed** will inherit the gate of their enemies,
a' ¹⁸ and all the nations of the land will find **blessing** in your seed,
on the heel of the fact that you listened to my voice."

¹⁹ And Avraham returned to his young men,
and they arose **and they went together as one** to Beer-**Sheva** (= Well of **Seven** (שבוע))
and Avraham dwelt in Beer-**Sheva**.

Genesis 22:1-19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Avraham Surrenders and Regains Yitskhaq From Death

With this story, God's journey with Avraham comes to a culminating point. The opening of this story contains multiple hyperlinks back to God's first "test" of Avraham's faithfulness. The fact that it recalls God's call to Avraham in [Genesis 12:1-6](#) leads us to think that the entirety of God's blessing (introduced in [Gen. 12:1-3](#)) hangs in the balance. As we read through to the end of this episode, this hunch is confirmed (see [22:18](#)).

Genesis 12:1-6

Gen. 12:1 "Get yourself going (לך לך) from your land (ארץ) ... to the land (אל הארץ) which I will show you (אשר אראך)."

Gen. 12:6 "And Avram passed through the land ... to the oak tree of Moreh (מורה)."

Gen. 12:3 "And all the families of the land will find blessing **through you**."

Genesis 22

Gen. 22:2 "Get yourself going (לך לך) to the land (אל ארץ) of Moriah (מריה) ... where I will speak to you (אשר אמר אליך)."

Gen. 22:18 "And all the nations of the land will discover blessing **through your seed**."

Genesis 22 Replays 12. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

"Just as Abraham had to leave all that he held dear to go to the land prescribed by the Lord (see 12:1), so he has to offer to the Lord what he holds most dear and worship where God chooses (see Deut. 12:5)."

Waltke, Bruce K. and Cathi J. Fredricks (2001). [Genesis: A Commentary](#). Zondervan. 305.

This "test" (Heb. *nissah* / נִסָּה) is the culmination of God's relationship with Avraham and of Avraham and Sarah's sinful abuse of Hagar and Yishmael. Recall the tight parallel relationships between this story and Avraham's loss of Yishmael in [Genesis 21:1-21](#).

Genesis 20:1-18

A - Avraham and Avimelek: Conflict Caused by Deception

Genesis 21:1-21

B - Avraham Loses His Son Yishmael, Whose Life Is Spared by God

- Yitskhaq is born
- Sarah and Yitskhaq separate from Hagar and Yishmael
- Avraham sends mother and son to die in wilderness
- God provides **water of life ("Well of Seven")** to save the endangered son
- God will make Yishmael into a great nation

Genesis 21:22-34

A' - Avraham and Avimelek: Conflict Resolved by Covenant

Genesis 22:1-19

B' - Avraham Loses His Son Yitskhaq, Whose Life Is Spared by God

- Yitskhaq is about to die

- Sarah and Avraham are to separate from Yitskhaq
- Avraham is to give Yitskhaq over to death on Mount Moriah
- God provides a substitute ram to save the endangered son
- God will bless all nations through Avraham's seed
- Avraham retires with his son to the **Well of Seven**

Genesis 20:1-22:19 (Simplified). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This clear set of hyperlinks between Avraham's loss and Yishmael and Yitskhaq make it clear that they are interrelated. This provides the crucial narrative context for God's test of Avraham. He and Sarah were willing to sacrifice their moral integrity and abuse a slave in order to gain the promised son by their own wisdom. That sin resulted in the expulsion of the slave and her son, and here another result comes about. If Avraham is going to be God's vehicle of blessing to the nations, God requires his faithfulness and total surrender: Will Avraham hand over the life of his son to God, trusting that God will be able to fulfill his promises, even in the face of death?

This is the first biblical narrative where God is said to "test" his chosen one to discern their faithfulness. It is a rich theme that was introduced in the Eden story with the tree of knowing good and bad, and it carries forward into multiple stories that echo this motif.

God Tests ...	Verse
Adam and Eve at the Tree	Gen. 2:16-17 The LORD God commanded the man, saying, "From any tree of the garden you may eat freely; but from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat from it you will surely die."
Noah With the Building of the Ark	Gen. 6:13-14 Then God said to Noah ... "Make for yourself an ark of gopher trees; you shall make the ark with rooms, and shall cover it inside and out with pitch."
Israel at the Waters of Meribah	Exod. 15:25 Then he cried out to the LORD, and the LORD showed him a tree; and he threw it into the waters, and the waters became sweet. There he made for them a statute and regulation, and there he tested them .
Israel With the Manna	Exod. 16:4 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Behold, I will rain bread from heaven for you; and the people shall go out and gather a day's portion every day, that I may test them , whether or not they will walk in my instruction."
Israel at Mount Sinai	Exod. 20:20 Moses said to the people, "Do not be afraid; for God has come in order to test you , and in order that the fear of him may remain with you, so that you may not sin."

Tests in the Torah and Judges. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

God Tests ...	Verse
Israel as They Wander in the Wilderness	Deut. 8:2 "You shall remember all the way which the LORD your God has led you in the wilderness these forty years, that he might humble you, testing you , to know what was in your heart, whether you would keep his commandments or not."
Israel With the Remaining Canaanite Nations	Judg. 2:21-23 "I also will no longer drive out before them any of the nations which Joshua left when he died, in order to test Israel by them , whether they will keep the way of the LORD to walk in it as their fathers did, or not." So the Lord allowed those nations to remain, not driving them out quickly; and he did not give them into the hand of Joshua.
<i>Tests in the Torah and Judges. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

The core pattern revolves around God testing his chosen one to determine if they will follow his instruction and so become a vehicle of his blessing to others. God's words at the story's climax confirm this is the goal of Avraham's test.

⁹ And they went to **the place which Elohim said to him**,
and Avraham built there an altar,
and he arranged the **wood**,
and he bound up **Yitskhaq his son**,
and he placed him upon the altar atop the **wood**,
¹⁰ and Avraham **sent out his hand**,
and he took the **eater [= knife]** to slay **his son**,
¹¹ **and the messenger of Yahweh called to him from the skies**,
and he said,
"Avraham! Avraham!"
and he said,
"Look, it's me!"
¹² **And he said**,
"**Don't send out your hand** toward the young one!
And don't do anything to him,
because now I know that you are one who fears Elohim,
and you didn't withhold **your son, your only one**, from me."

Genesis 22:1-19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

God Tests Abraham. Does God Test God?

It makes sense of the narrative logic that God would test Abraham and call him to account for his sins against Hagar. In Abraham's earlier failures, he was the one threatening God's promise of a future seed who will bless the nations. But in this story, God is the one threatening the future of God's own promise.

This story invites the reader into a deep mystery at the heart of the biblical narrative: God's own purpose and promise is what determines the future of the cosmos. But God has also willed that his human partners would be the primary vehicle through which his purposes are carried out. Abraham is both the problem and the solution for God's promise to bless the nations. And Abraham and Sarah's story is itself a micro-cosmic replay of humanity's role in the biblical story: Humans are both God's problem and the solution to his purposes.

This narrative tension is not resolved by the rest of the biblical narrative. Rather, it is heightened to a crisis point by the end of the Hebrew Bible. In this way, the story of Jesus presented in the gospels is the natural outcome of this theological tension: God becomes the faithful human partner he has called us to be, but we often fail to be.

We often fail, but not always! In this story, Abraham is presented as a model of faithfulness because he is willing to surrender the beloved son of God's promise over to God's own paradoxical purpose. This powerful image is repeated in the story of Moses' self-sacrifice for the sins of Israel ([Exod. 32-33](#)), in David's self-sacrifice for his own sins that are afflicting Israel ([2 Sam. 24](#)), and ultimately in the composite figure of the suffering servant of Isaiah 40-55, who, we're told ...

Isaiah 53:7 NASB

He was oppressed and he was afflicted,
yet he did not open his mouth;
like a lamb that is led to slaughter,
and like a sheep that is silent before its shearers,
so he did not open his mouth.

Mount Moriah, Jerusalem, and the Temple

Mount Moriah (מֹרִיָּה = "Mount Vision") links back to the "oak of Moreh" (מֹרֶה) from [Genesis 12:6](#), creating an inclusion around all of Genesis 12-22. Also, Mount Moriah has clear hyperlinks forward to the temple mount where David will later establish the site for the temple.

The phrase "mountain of Yahweh" (הַר יְהוָה) in [Genesis 22:14](#) is used once for Mount Sinai ([Num. 10:33](#)) but elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible always refers to Mount Zion, the temple mount in Jerusalem (see [Isa. 2:3](#), [30:29](#); [Mic. 4:2](#); [Zech. 8:3](#); [Ps. 24:3](#)).

"Mount Moriah" only appears one more time in the Hebrew Bible, as the location where the events of David's great test take place in [2 Samuel 24](#).

2 Chronicles 3:1 Instructor's Translation

And Solomon began to build the house of Yahweh in Jerusalem on **Mount Moriah**, where Yahweh had appeared to his father David, which he established at the place of David, **on the threshing floor of Ornan**

Avraham's Hilltop Sacrifice Pattern



Avraham's Hilltop Sacrifice Pattern. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

Do we, the readers, have any reason to believe that God will not take the life of Yitskhaq? What information do we have that Avraham does not?